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Jack Lesberg

Versatility has been the key behind the career of bassist Jack Lesberg. Jack was born in Boston on February 14, 1920 and started on the violin as a child. He played in public at an early age, eventually finding the string bass as his instrument of choice. Throughout his career he has alternated between jazz, classical and commercial studio work and his lengthy discography speaks highly of the respect that fellow musicians hold for his work. Leonard Bernstein, Louis Armstrong, Tommy Dorsey and Sarah Vaughan are a few of the giants of American music who have employed Jack. He has toured the world numerous times and continues to perform at jazz venues across the country.

Jack was interviewed by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 11, 1997. In addition to performing, Jack co-directed this event with longtime friend, pianist Ralph Sutton.

MR: Today we're interviewing in Aspen, Colorado. I'm very pleased to be talking today with Jack Lesberg, who is a bass player who has played on hundreds of records. And probably we've heard you numerous times on T.V. shows and all those kinds of things, maybe not knowing who it was.

JL: Yeah, it's very possible.

MR: Yeah. You have had a very interesting career and been around the world. Now you've got your hand in actually organizing festivals too.

JL: That's right.

MR: You have enough to do these days?

JL: Yeah, well I've enjoyed it. It's always been fun trying to call somebody you like and tell them you've got a job for them. That's kind of fun, I enjoy doing it.

MR: When you were a youth, was there music in your house a lot?

JL: Quite a bit, yeah, actually. My brother was a professional violinist. He was about — let me see, Dave would have been — oh he was about 13 or 14 years older than I am. He was born in Russia actually. I was born in Boston in 1920. And my sister also played the violin. And I also took the violin. There is about six or seven years between us. There's quite a spread in the family there. And I played the violin and viola, and studied with a very fine teacher at Boston, Carl Barladen was his name. He was with the Boston Symphony Orchestra under Karl Muok. It goes way back to those kind of names. But he was a very — and he was 80 years old at that time, Carl Barladen was. And so my brother and sister had both studied with him previously. And I played the violin and viola, and studied with him for about I guess five years or six years, and I played it

dinner hour or something like that. And then I went on and I played in clubs. They had after hour clubs. And an after hour club was one that opened about eleven or twelve o'clock at night when the legitimate clubs so to speak were closing, and you could get a drink in there. And they had trios and quartets that consisted of either violin, the cello — not the cello — violin and guitar and bass, occasionally a piano might have been in there. And people used to come in there, and they were quite orderly places, and we worked, and they must have had about 18 or 20 of them all around the Boston area. They were very popular. And they would stay open until about five or six o'clock in the morning. And that's what I used to do when I was going to my early years at English High School.

MR: No kidding.

JL: Yeah.

MR: How did you stay awake in class?

JL: Well it was just amazing. I was pretty good, fortunately I was pretty good with my studies too, so I used to do most of the homework there, on the study periods, and I managed to get out of the military training, they didn't think I was too good at that so I had an extra study period there.

MR: You had military training in the school?

JL: Yeah, they had a training. It was a boys school, English High School, they had a girl's version of it as well there, but they were city schools, very large schools.

MR: Did the music that you played earlier in the day, differed from the music that you played in the after hours club?

JL: Well, yeah, because I was playing with these wonderful little groups. They were marvelous guitar players, you know, like Bucky Pizzarelli here, they were those kind of players, family players that all played in the family. Everybody in their family played guitar, but mostly Italian families. And they were brilliant players, really. They just learned, well it was handed down in the family. And I had formal training, with Carl Barladen during those days, and it was just great to fall in and be able to play with these wonderful guitar players. And I did that for quite a while, until that one period there. It was kind of funny story. I wound up joining a group called The Strings of Romance which, you can take that however you like.

MR: I like that name.

JL: Don't touch it, huh? Well it consisted of a couple of guitars, and one of the guitarists played mandolin, I played the violin, and they had a chap there that played the bass, but not too good, kind of poorly. And the manager of the restaurant there that we were playing at out there decided he could save a few by just having me play the bass. I'd sit in and touch the bass a little bit while he sang. And so anyways, I wound up getting to the

was playing with, the guitar players, they all played the bass too. They all just played it by rote, you know they just had the ears for the chords and the changes and the intonation. They all got nice sounds on it. And so I started playing the bass at that period, when I was about 18 years old, while playing the violin as well. And then I wound up, my first — I worked in some of those clubs again playing the bass, and I wound up working at the Coconut Grove, which you've probably heard of, and I was in the Coconut Grove fire in 19 — I guess it was '42, November 28 I guess. And it was a very tragic fire. You remember, there were three or four —

MR: How did you manage to —

JL: I was carried out of there. I was carried out unconscious and I was quite ill there, in the hospital for about a month or so. And I survived it fine and my lungs and everything cleared out and I made my way out of there. And at this time I was already playing the bass, because I'd been playing floor shows there with it and doing all kinds of other things. And I didn't really start studying the bass formally — I did have this other training, I studied the piano as well early when I was a kid. And when I got to New York — I went to New York in about 1944, and there was this marvelous array of teachers and everything, and amongst them was Fred Zimmermann, one of the best. And that was the way to go. I just inquired around and I went to him and I studied with him for about seven years. And we got along famously. He was very, very wonderful and dedicated teacher, a young guy, and young acting, one of those kind of guys. And he taught practically everybody. He taught at Juilliard as well. But I studied privately with him, and I was lucky enough to have him for several years. Quite a few, almost all the bass players went to him. He was that good.

MR: So you worked on the technique of the bass with him. And your jazz playing, was that something you worked on with him or was that more self-taught?

JL: Well I did jazz playing, not so much with him, no. He had a feel for it. You know he was with the Philharmonic and he taught at Juilliard during that period. He wasn't a jazz player but he was loose. He was a good golfer, he was a marvelous painter, and he loved the bass, he adored the bass. And he was just — I studied privately and he taught at Juilliard but I just studied privately with him. And as time went on he was very kind to me and I used to come in evenings and he'd play duets with me and things like that. And then eventually he even sent me to, he recommended me to take his place with "The Bell Telephone Hour" — he was playing on that show. Donald Voorhees was the conductor, I don't know, you wouldn't have remembered it, but you'll find they were all NBC. When I came to New York, in '44, '45, I was very lucky and I got on a staff job at NBC, which meant that I had a steady job for that period and I also got a chance to play with the NBC

Symphony and as well as the dance orchestra. Eddie Safranski and I were the two hot guys, and they would add us to the other six who were playing with the NBC Orchestra.

MR: Is that the term they used, the "hot guys?"

JL: Well maybe — no I think that's my own. No we weren't that hot. But we did play with the dance orchestra, you know they'd have Bing Crosby come out, because these were all staff programs you know, not so much, it was all radio just then. And I had a lot of experience with that. I stayed with the station there just for a short period you know. I was taking a serviceman's place, he was called to service, and that's how I got the job.

MR: I was going to ask you if the war years affected you.

JL: Well the Coconut Grove helped me get out of there. It wasn't a help in the fire, but it did get me out of going in the service. And they were all ready to take me until I told them that I didn't think they were being real nice to me about it. I had gone through the fire and everything else, after I had tried to get in and I was rejected then at that time. And I says after I go through the fire, you think I'm in pretty good shape, forget it you know? And besides supporting my mother and father. And so anyways they let me out of that. And then I went to New York and these things happened. And I was very lucky. I got on the staff as I say at NBC and was let go eventually, and I opened the Eddie Condon Club in 1945. And that was just — you know the whole thing with running into just about everybody in the jazz affair.

MR: That was quite a time I guess, and the whole Condon aura.

JL: It was fantastic.

MR: I mean was it as interesting as they say?

JL: It was very interesting, and I'm having a second awakening with it because it's so many years ago and it's just so hard to remember so much of that. During that period we had done a whole gang of radio shows for the armed services with Eddie Condon. And a fellow by the name of Ernie Anderson was a marvelous promoter and a marvelous entrepreneur. And he had organized these things where we played for the armed services and we had weekly programs, you know with people like Ernie Caceres, Jack Teagarden, Louis Armstrong, Jess Stacey — the names galore, as they're all historical more or less now. And I had a chance to play with all of them and they had just released — I just got a whole bunch of CDs from them that have just been released by some chap down in St. Louis, I just can't think of his name offhand. And boy I've been listening and they're just a ball. They're recorded marvelously. Especially these ones they've made in the last few years. I guess Ernie Anderson had spent quite a length of the last years of his life — he just died this past year. But he evidently spent a lot of his time and used his knowledge and common sense in getting good engineers and especially the last few of them are very

well recorded, and it's really a kick just to sit in there. I've spent hours just listening to them. I play with them a little bit, just to practice, to see what you were doing.

MR: See if you can keep up with yourself.

JL: Yeah. I'd just fall into the same lines that I was playing in those years. It was pretty funny.

MR: That's great.

JL: Yeah. It's a ball.

MR: Condon wasn't known for his soloing but he certainly was a catalyst.

JL: Oh, yeah, oh he was a terrific catalyst, yeah. And he was fun. He wasn't a great player or anything, but he did have — there are certain things that he enjoyed and they were great jazz things, like having people like Lee Wiley as one of the singers, and having, he had Louis Armstrong on the program, and Jack Teagarden I think was recording for some company and they couldn't use his name and so they called him "Pete Pesky" or something like that. And all the way through this he's playing the trombone. And Ernie Caceres is one of them. But they're all just marvelous famous names in those days. And I was just 25 or 35 or whatever it was, I can't figure it out now.

MR: Mid '40s.

JL: Yes.

MR: What was a night of work at Condon's like? What time did you start?

JL: Well you had to be in pretty good shape to take it you know, because there was plenty of drinking going on there, and smoking cigarettes and what have you. There was a lot of action going on there all the time, but it was fun and all the musicians came in there. And I met Leonard Bernstein there. He loved jazz music. And he used to come in through the back door, underneath door, it was just funny the way the door was, and he got along famously with Eddie. Eddie was just, he was a terrific. They just thought he was the best thing since cream cheese. They had a lot of fun with him. And Leonard and, oh the other marvelous composer, David Diamond was his sidekick then. And they used to come in there quite often, and I eventually — Leonard asked me if I'd like to go and audition. He knew I was studying with Fred, and he says why don't you go and audition for the — he was taking over the City Center Symphony. And I had a feel and background for this kind of music just from my studies that I had been doing through then, and the violin and the viola that I'd studied previously. And I was studying with Fred at the time and so after about a year or so — I didn't take him up on it the first year — but the second year that I was there I went up and auditioned for him and this was the City Center Symphony that he conducted for about three years. And it was a marvelous orchestra. They played a lot of the standard repertoire of those days, and you know, all the Bach and Beethoven

MR: Some of his own work perhaps?

JL: Well yeah, there was some of that and David Diamond was a marvelous composer and they would do some of his things. And they just loved the idea of having a hot cat down there. They really enjoyed it. They really had a lot of fun out of it all.

MR: And while you were doing that you were still playing in the evenings?

JL: Well I didn't stay at Condon's very long after that. I got quite busy with studios and I wound up, oh I did the original Milton Berle Show when it went color, with color T.V. That started a whole new era there. And I was on The Bell Telephone Hour, and The Hit Parade with Raymond Scott for a number of years I did. I freelanced. I found I preferred freelancing. I missed a couple of good things that I wanted to do, and when you were on staff there you could only work a certain number of days, it had certain limitations there. And it was very little money that they paid you, on a staff basis. I mean it was not bad for those days, probably $125 a week and you'd put in about four hours a day, three or four hours a day or maybe less if you weren't busy then you could do other work. But anyways that's the way it went on during those days. I've had some wonderful breaks in my life.

MR: Well I was looking at this little discography and so forth, and during the 40s alone you were with Louis Armstrong and Teagarden and Coleman Hawkins and Sidney Bechet and Sarah Vaughan. Either you couldn't hold a job or people liked you.

JL: Sarah, I played her audition. And Leonard Feather had her up there and they had George Auld. We didn't get any money for it. And she was about 15 years old. She was a scrawny little gal. And I got to know her very well later in years. She came to Australia when I lived there and I toured with her for George Wein later on. And so it was a wonderful relationship knowing people of different parts of the jazz music and the scene. People like Ruby Braff, and some unusual musicians.

MR: When you went to do the studio work for different artists, you basically show up at the time appointed and they'd put the music in front of you and you were expected to do it right.

JL: They were commercial recordings, and it may have a vocalist that you were accompanying or pop songs that were getting popular at that time or that they were trying to make popular. And jingles, when the television era started it was a whole different gang of work you know. They were usually bookings for an hour or an hour and a half. And those musicians were all fantastic. They were mostly dance guys. Many of them played with the symphony as well. But mostly those kind of players. And they'd come in for a one hour jingle or something, to do a couple of spots and maybe with one hour with a possible 15, that's the way they were booked.

JL: Yeah, that was a popular phrase from Radio Registry. An hour and a half or two hours with a possible 20 or something.

MR: So they built that into the studio schedule where it might go 15 minutes into overtime.

JL: Into their schedule and into your schedule so that, if they didn't book you for that time, when it came to that time you'd say well I'm sorry I've got to go across the street. That's the way the guys would work it. They'd get all these little checks later on, and take it right to the bar and cash them.

MR: And was there a place that you fellows would hang out?

JL: Oh, yeah.

MR: And you'd get a phone call?

JL: Oh famous places, yeah. Well Jim & Andy's was one of the later more popular ones. Because he would just see you. And Hurley's. Hurley's still exists at the corner of 50th and Sixth Avenue. It's a little corner shaped building and the Hurley family owned it, an Irish family. And when they built the RCA building there, they wouldn't sell. And if you ever go by the building you'll notice that that corner building is a two-story brownstone that's right into the RCA building still, all these years. And the family just owned it all that time, and they were marvelous characters. And the shows like the early days of the hit parade, they used to do two shows. They did an early show that went out to the audience around the eastern part of the country, and then they would do one at 9:30 or something that went out to California. They were done live. They didn't quite figure out how to do it on tape. They did it on tape but they didn't have that thing going there. And there was quite a difference between the night show and the early show. And they'd spend the whole intermission at Jim & Andy's or Hurley's. But they were wonderful players. A lot of the guys like McGarrity and Urbie Green and all the wonderful players were part of the orchestra. Raymond Scott was, his brother had died who was the early conductor of the Hit Parade, and it was just a lot of fun with these guys.

MR: So if some producer in the studio had a need all of a sudden for a bass trombone player, could they just call this place?

JL: They'd have a contractor who acted as their contractor, or people that they knew from working other programs. One led to another after a while. And they used strings a great deal, you know, for backing up what they were trying to do, and trying to glamorize the product. And they wound up with — it wasn't for nothing that you would find the concertmaster of the Philharmonic playing in a jingle because they'd go in there for an hour and they'd make more than they made for the orchestra for a week. That's the way it was then. I mean apparently it's changed since then of course.

MR: What was scale back then?

JL: Well I can't remember exactly. I think it ran, it might have run anywhere from $40 to $50 for the hour or something like that, then the overtime. So if you went in for a couple of hours, it could be $100 or $75. Those things kept — and they had residuals to them as well. If they were used over a ten week period or something like that why there would be another part. So you'd go in to the union after ten weeks or some time, you'd be apt to find repayments on some of these — you know, cigarette commercials and things like that that were going on then. And as I told you you would just run to Jim & Andy's with all those immediately. That was like found money. Lots of nice drinks.

MR: Productive time for music in New York, for musicians anyway.

JL: Yeah it was exciting. The guys were all full of fun I think and hung together. A good lot really.

MR: Milt Hinton credits you with a big break in his career. How did that come about?

JL: He's a great friend. Well I had the chance to recommend him. There was a period then when I was doing the Hit Parade and some of these other programs, that, when television started you know there was a lot of these commercials, like cigarette commercials of course. They didn't like the idea of having blacks on their program, you know, coming from where the tobacco came from, and it was against their principles and so forth. So there was that kind of thing that was going on for a while. And also with Milt was the fact that he came after I'd been there for quite a while. I was quite established as a studio player. You know that's the way it went. And I had a chance to recommend Milt to one of the shows that I was leaving. And it worked and it was a big start. He'd been there for a long time and just couldn't crack that. Milt is a very marvelous man. He's an extremely talented guy and a very inner strength. He's just terrific. And he played very well. He did everything that he was supposed to do and he did it the right way, he just went out and did it. He got himself the instruments, he went to the places where the guys were, and he was just great. He just fell in it. But you couldn't catch him after that.

MR: He was on the fast track.

JL: Oh, yeah, he was in with some hot — of course Bob Haggart is one of our, he was one of the first around those years too.

MR: Well Milt then was one of the first black musicians to crack the market so to speak.

JL: He was, yeah. And a couple of the guys from the Hit Parade finally put some on, I just can't think of some of the names. I can see their faces but it just got by me for a minute.

MR: What was the women's — the Housewives Protective League?

JL: Where'd you hear that? I'm not familiar with that.

MR: I thought that was a T.V. show or something that you were on?

JL: Housewives Protective League. Tell me a little more, maybe it'll—

JL: Oh yeah?

MR: And he said something about that you were doing two shows and you had to choose between one or the other.

JL: Well that's right, yes. That's where I had the chance to turn him on and of course that was a great step for him he felt. But as I say he just didn't need much coaching, he was gone.

MR: Because then he talks about getting into that life where he was doing three sessions a day.

JL: Right.

MR: And he had to have a couple of basses in different parts of the city.

JL: Oh he was terrific, yeah, he had work then, we all did. We had some little guy who just used to pick them all up and move them after a while. I don't know how he did it — he'd go downstairs with a baritone and a bass and saxophones and he'd squeeze them all into a taxi somehow or another and get them down to the date, yeah. Yeah it was pretty hilarious. You'd just call him the night before. It was kind of fun how the system — the Radio Registry was the big answering — it was before the answerphones. I wish they were still there in that way. But you could just tell them you were going to be out of town or I'll be at Jim & Andy's bar from five 'til nine or something like that.

MR: Well gee that way you get to talk to a person when you call them, and they know where you are.

JL: Oh it was marvelous.

MR: Instead of getting an answer machine, you don't know when people are going to call you back.

JL: The machine actually drives me crazy. I never get it right. I'm always messing it up. I think I have it, and especially at this stage of life, it plays a lot of games with me. You tell them your number or your name, and I've immediately forgotten it by the time I hang up.

MR: Well gosh you've been around the world a number of times. With Louis Armstrong.

JL: Yeah.

MR: Tell me about some of your favorites.

JL: Well the one with Louis, I was originally called with Louis, this goes back to Ernie Anderson also. Louis came in town, he had done a movie and Billie Holiday was in the movie, and I forget the other name of the actor, it was in the 40s.

MR: Oh, yeah, was that "Saint Louis Blues?"

JL: Something like that. And what's her name, Billie Holiday was in the picture as well. And I was working at Condon's at the time. And Ernie Anderson thought it would be a marvelous idea for Louis to have the All Stars. That's when that concept came up. And Ernie was very much behind that thing. Louis was managed by Joe Glaser for the years.

him into trying that. And they wanted me — Arvell Shaw was working with Louis' band. Louis had a big band in those days. And this was during the days when I was still connected with Eddie Condon a lot. But I was pretty busy with the studios and the jobs — they were going out for a tour, they had fixed up a tour to try it I think. Ernie finally got I think Earl Hines and Louis and oh I'm not too sure, Edmond Hall was on it with me when I went later on, and Barney Bigard and Velma Middleton. I think they fixed up about a six piece band and they went out. And they went over there supposedly for about two or three weeks and I think they were there for about six months. Every time they went to get on the plane to go back, one of the other countries wanted to take them. And it kept on. So it became a thing. And I felt very much left out. I just couldn't leave my — you know this was bread and butter and starting a family and all that stuff. So anyways a period went by there until finally, I worked with Louis a lot and made records with him. I did some single dates with him. But then he finally had, they called me to go to Australia with him for a tour, and then they came back and went to Great Britain and then to Africa from there. It was about a three month period. And I finally went to Raymond Scott and I says I just got a call to do this thing and I've been waiting to do it, and whether you let me go or not, if you want to fire me, I says, be my guest. So he was very nice. He let me off for about three months or so and I did this tour. And we went to Africa and it was just all very, very exciting. I remember it all so well, that part of it, it was just really thrilling. And he wanted me to come back with them. They were coming back to play one of the outdoor concerts with Leonard Bernstein, and I guess the word was around, Leonard found out that I was with Louis now, and he thought this would be a wonderful tie in, you know, with Louis and having him there and having me there, having been with him before all that. Because I did know him quite well at that time. He was really a swell guy. He actually put me on as Associate Principal when I went with the orchestra, with that City Central Symphony when I went with him. He was a great guy to do that and it just gave me a lot of extra courage really to keep moving with it. But that was the start of the All Stars, that period there that I didn't go. Then later on Louis went on and I played quite a bit with him after that. And then I did move to Australia. I loved it there and I moved there I think in the early 70s for about five years and I played with the Sydney Symphony. I auditioned for them and I played with them.

MR: Was there a jazz scene in Australia?

JL: Oh yes. There is, yeah. This chap that played with us now was in a quartet that I did.

MR: Oh. Bob Bernard?

JL: Bob Bernard, yeah. I got a job at the American National Club. It didn't pay hardly anything but I had that with the symphony. And also I didn't accept the position on a

nervousness from freelancing, I figured I might lose something. And in fact I loved Sydney and I'm sorry I left it now. I would have loved to stay there. I made many friends there and it's a nice country, it really is. But I did come back, due to marital stuff, and I came back I guess close to 1980. And then I started, I got some calls to tour Europe and I was free to do it, I was on my own again so that's about where we are.

MR: And we've arrived in Aspen.

JL: And Aspen is almost over. I've been doing these parties for a long time too.

MR: Well there seems to be a healthy, I'm not sure about the whole state of jazz, but there seems to be a healthy interest in the veteran musicians and the music they've been playing for years.

JL: Yeah. You mean as far as the jazz? I think so, yeah, I think so. There's just these wonderful players like we have here — you see some of the cases that are up here. The guys — I don't know if there's any that are older than me, but pretty close.

MR: When you look at the future of this mainstream jazz, if we can use that term I suppose, what do you see for it in the future?

JL: Tough question for me to answer. I don't, I just don't know. I can't give you a real thought. You know I find myself in the position now, I'm sort of just hanging on with it a little bit. There's all the younger people, as it was when I was hot coming through at the time. That goes on now and they like to stick together, and no matter how you put it, they'll go through it too.

MR: Well there's some great young players out there and I hope we get a great young audience for them.

JL: Yeah. You mean talking about here, now?

MR: Yeah.

JL: Oh, yeah, oh these people here they just love it boy. Outasight.

MR: They're so into it, you know, they respond to the solos and all that.

JL: They just love it boy, they're real fans.

MR: Out of all the people you've played with, does any couple numbers of them stand out as far as their sense of humor?

JL: Pretty tough to beat the one right at the beginning there, with Eddie Condon. That was a laugh a minute in those days. Everybody was having a ball and knew everything. I'd go to work sometimes at night and get home three days later.

MR: Somehow you wonder how you survived that, huh?

JL: Well you didn't hurt yourself, it was just fine. You know those days in New York, it was easy. You could go out at night. It wasn't if you hung out at night or if you wound up in Harlem or as they say and things like that and visiting some of those clubs where you

when I came in there, they were playing two pianos in there. Maxie Kaminsky had just come back from with Artie Shaw's band and he put a band together and it was Willie Smith and Rod Kless I remember, myself, and a couple of guys, and James P. Johnson and the Lion were the two pianos. They had a grand piano and an upright piano, and Willie played intermission and they would open at seven o'clock at night and they'd play 'till five, six in the morning. And all these, you know, fantastic piano players would come in, you know, Duke, all of them. These were the Daddies. Those were the days. When you were living around those days and you'd go in to do — the people that were on, talking about the Jack Teagardens and Hackett and Benny Goodman. You know, really giant players, so many that you'd come across. I don't know whether you can top those periods. These records are a kick listening back to what you were doing and playing and these guys were good and peppy. They were really — Ernie Caceres on baritone sax was just irreplaceable, some of these guys — Joe Temperley just talked about Ernie Caceres, he says that oh, he missed him, that he was just so sad about what he used to do. This guy was great.

MR: Well we do refer to it as the Golden Age of jazz.

JL: I guess. Well I'm having a big kick listening to these tapes again. Lee Wiley was on these things. I get a big charge out of listening to what I was doing and the intensity of it, and it seemed to roll off ya. And a lot of it is very close to the way I run my lines and things like that today.

MR: Did you have influences on the bass? People that you emulated?

JL: Well one of the first guys I came across, and he was about my age or a little bit younger, was Ray Brown. Because when I left Condon's, the bit was at Condon's there that they finally let the bass go down there to save some money, to save the salary. Because everybody that came in there sat in on the bass. So they figured they could get the bass for free. So I always used to say they cut the strings at Eddie Condon's. That was my line. I forgot what I was trying to say—

MR: Ray Brown.

JL: Yeah, Ray. I went up to work on 52nd Street and I played with Teagarden and Maxie and Peanuts Hucko and Cliff Leeman, whose wife is here. And Louis came in and sat in and played with us at The Famous Door. That's where I was working. But 52nd Street was just full of those places you know. Billie Holiday was singing on one corner and you'd just walk down the street or cut over and stand across the street and hear who you wanted to hear from the other place. Yeah it was really a kick, 52nd Street. You'll never see that again.

MR: Yeah some of us were born in the wrong era I think.

JL: When you walk down 52nd Street today, I go by those, the block that they were in and I say oh it's too bad.

MR: Oh, yeah. Well at least you got to experience it, to be part of it.

JL: Yeah. But those were the people. Let's see, Ella walking down the street going to work singing some of the tunes as she's walking along that are running through her head, and just having a good time. It was quite exciting days, everybody going to those wonderful little bars around the corner and so forth.

MR: Well I think you've done a great job here in Aspen, having a hand in mixing and matching the musicians.

JL: Well I've enjoyed doing that. It wears your head down, I mean to try to do it, when you finally get to a point where you have so many musicians and such a limited time. You know and you start figuring the time of changing from one band to another. It's quick but when you think of the time that you're fooling with I mean we used to spend that much time just talking in between the tunes.

MR: Sure. And you want to give everybody a little solo spot.

JL: So you're trying to do this and just keep away from the — you know just band, band, band. You're always trying to open it a little bit here and there for a bit. And the more players you have the tougher it gets to try to do it in a period of time. You kind of wish you could. But it works. And the people provide all the other, the human part of it.

MR: What's in the immediate future for you?

JL: Well I just hope I can keep playing. I love to play. And as I say I very fortunately still have some contacts and get over to Europe a bit and occasionally for a tour. I've been over with Ralph, he's quite busy in that area and we're old buddies and I work with him quite often. I just hope to keep moving. I spend some time, I like to practice, with a couple of guys around New York, John Bunch being one of them who lives nearby and he has a big Steinway in his living room and he's got a bass that I strung up, it's in a corner there. And if he's got some time he likes to play. He doesn't like to practice but he likes to play. But I like to practice, I do, but I like to play, of course that's important. So he'll call, "you feel like it?" I say okay, and I just jump on the tram, I live over at Roosevelt Island, and I just hop up there and take off my hat and coat and we play.

MR: Well I'm glad you haven't lost that passion. That's great.

JL: Oh it's important. It's the only way. And also I like to play some of the symphonic music again. That's a very wonderful, rewarding part of it. It's difficult and it keeps your attention and you keep together and all that stuff with other instruments. You know I look at these bandstands and everybody's kind of squashed in getting near the piano and all that. And I go crazy there, trying to figure out a corner for me to squeeze in there. You go

out in a symphony there you've got a block long of violins, nobody's having any problem.

MR: Right. That's a luxury.

JL: Anyhow, thanks for giving me the chance to talk about it. I enjoy talking about it.

MR: Yeah. Very fascinating.

JL: I enjoyed it.

MR: Looking forward to hearing some more music tonight. And I hope that bass behaves for you this evening.

JL: I've been down there for two hours. I finally found, there's a crack in it. So fortunately one of the engineers was very kind. I ran into him on the street and boy he just saved me, he spent an hour with me.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College, I want to thank you for joining us. I look forward to your playing tonight.

JL: Thanks for the opportunity.

MR: Okay.

JL: I enjoyed talking to you. Okay. All the best.